

How to Start a Moving Company in 2026: The Complete Guide

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How to Start a Moving Company in 2026: The Complete Guide

This is the full step-by-step launch guide — from market research to first customers. For a quick overview of the 2026 landscape and key risks, see *Starting a Moving Company? Here's What You Need to Know in 2026*.

The moving industry generates over \$86 billion annually in the US, and the majority of that flows through independent local operators — not PetiteMoving or Two Men and a Truck franchises. The market is massive, fragmented, and genuinely accessible to individual operators willing to build correctly.

Here's how to do it right.

Is This Business Right for You?

Before spending a dollar, be honest about what this requires.

The moving business is:

- Physically demanding (especially early on, when you're likely on the truck)
- Operationally complex (logistics, scheduling, crew management, claims)
- Reputation-dependent (one bad review can follow you for years)
- Seasonal (summer demand can be 2 to 3x winter demand in many markets)

The moving business rewards:

- Operators who are obsessive about customer experience
- Businesses with strong systems (checklists, training, communication protocols)
- Companies that treat marketing as a core function, not an afterthought

If you find the operational challenge energizing and have patience for building a reputation, this is an excellent business with a clear path to \$500k+ annual revenue.

Step 1: Research Your Market

Before touching equipment, spend 2 weeks on market research.

What you need to understand:

Local demand level: Search "movers [your city]" and count how many active companies appear on the first page. Look at Google Maps. How many operators have 50+ reviews? That tells you the market's maturity.

Price sensitivity: Call 5 to 8 competitors posing as a potential customer. Ask for a quote on a 2-bedroom apartment move. Record the rates. Note how they handle the quote — do they ask about distance, stairs, specialty items? This tells you how sophisticated the competition is.

Seasonal patterns: Moving demand peaks May to September in most US markets. Some markets (college towns, military bases) have specific demand spikes. Know your market's pattern before setting your business plan.

Review quality: Read 10 to 20 Google reviews of your top 3 competitors. What do customers complain about? What do they rave about? These are your opportunities.

Step 2: Get Legal and Licensed

Business structure:

Form an LLC (\$100 to \$800 depending on state). This is non-negotiable — moving involves customer property and physical risk. You need personal liability protection.

DOT requirements for intrastate (local) movers:

- USDOT number (free at [FMCSA.dot.gov](https://www.fmcsa.dot.gov))
- State carrier permit (varies by state, \$50 to \$500)
- Business license from city/county

For interstate moves (crossing state lines):

- FMCSA Operating Authority (MC number) — \$300, takes 4 to 6 weeks to process
- BOC-3 process agent filing — \$30 to \$75
- UCR registration — \$60 to \$80/year

Start local only if you're getting started quickly. Add interstate authority once you're established.

Step 3: Get the Right Equipment

The truck decision:

For most new operators, a used 24-foot box truck with 100,000 to 150,000 miles is the right starting point. Budget \$20,000 to \$30,000 for a solid truck. A pre-purchase mechanical inspection (\$150 to \$300) is mandatory before buying anything.

Key features to prioritize: working lift gate, functional air conditioning (you'll thank yourself in August), solid tires, no frame rust, clean hydraulics.

Moving equipment starter kit:

- 12 to 24 moving blankets
- 2 to 3 furniture dollies

- 1 appliance dolly (hand truck)
- 1 stair-climbing dolly (worth the investment early)
- 4 to 6 sets of moving straps
- Stretch wrap (3 to 4 rolls minimum on hand)
- Floor runners and door frame protection
- Basic disassembly toolkit (hex keys, screwdrivers, rubber mallet)

Total: \$1,000 to \$2,000 for a properly equipped truck.

Step 4: Insurance — Get This Right

Moving company insurance is complex. Get it wrong and one claim can end your business.

Required coverages:

1. **Commercial auto** for the truck(s)
2. **General liability** for property damage at customer locations
3. **Cargo liability** for damage to customer belongings during transit
4. **Workers' compensation** if you have employees (required in most states)

Budget \$550 to \$1,400/month for a single-truck operation without employees. Get quotes from at least 3 carriers — rates vary dramatically. Use an independent broker who works with transportation businesses.

The most dangerous mistake: Skipping cargo liability to save money. When a customer's antique dresser is damaged, cargo liability pays. Without it, you pay out of pocket — or get sued.

Step 5: Set Your Pricing

Calculate your hourly floor first:

Add up all your monthly costs (truck, insurance, fuel, maintenance, labor, supplies, overhead). Divide by your billable hours per month. That's your cost per hour — the floor below which you lose money.

For a standard 2-person crew with one truck: your floor is typically \$70 to \$85/hour.

Check your market:

From your competitor research in Step 1, you know what others charge. Position yourself at or near market midpoint initially. As your reviews build, you can charge a premium.

Build your complete rate card:

- Hourly rate by crew size
- Minimum hours (typically 2 to 3 hours)
- Travel/drive time policy (do you charge portal-to-portal or job-to-job?)
- Specialty item fees (pianos, safes, pool tables)
- Stair and access fees
- Fuel surcharge policy

Publish your base rates on your website. Transparency converts more inquiries than "call for a quote."

Step 6: Build Your Digital Foundation

Google Business Profile (free):

Your most important marketing asset. Fill every field. Add photos of your truck and crew (in uniform). Define your service area. Get this live before your first job.

Website:

Minimum requirements: service areas covered, move types offered, base pricing or price range, click-to-call button, online quote or booking form. Template sites (Squarespace, Wix) work fine at launch — \$20 to \$30/month.

Online booking capability:

Customers increasingly expect to book without calling. Tools like MoveHQ, Vonigo, or even a Calendly-based system for initial consultations significantly improve your conversion rate from website visits to booked jobs.

Step 7: Get Your First Customers

Week 1 to 2: Warm outreach

Every person in your network gets a message: "I just launched a moving company in [area]. If you or anyone you know is moving, I'd love the chance to earn their business."

Week 2 to 4: Apartment complex and realtor outreach

Apartment managers and real estate agents are perpetual referral sources. Call or visit 10 apartment complexes in your service area. Introduce yourself. Leave a business card and ask if they can refer tenants who are moving in or out.

Realtors are even more valuable — a single realtor who closes 2 to 3 houses per month can send you 6 to 10 moves per year consistently with no ongoing effort.

Month 1 to 3: Review generation

After every move, ask for a Google review. Use a direct link. Text it within 24 hours of job completion.

Your target: 15 reviews by month 3. Operators with 15+ reviews and a 4.5+ average dramatically outperform competitors with fewer reviews on Google Maps.

Month 2+: Add a paid demand channel

Google Ads, pay-per-move partnership, or both. The platform you can scale when you need more volume.

The First 90 Days: What to Focus On

Days 1 to 30: Operations and first jobs. Establish your systems, execute flawlessly, learn from every move.

Days 30 to 60: Reviews and Google Business Profile. Your digital reputation is the asset that compounds longest.

Days 60 to 90: Add a paid demand channel. By now you have reviews to convert the traffic you'll generate.

What Success Looks Like at 12 Months

A well-executed first year with one truck:

- 15 to 25 Google reviews, 4.6+ average
- 15 to 25 jobs per month consistently
- Monthly revenue \$12,000 to \$25,000
- Net margin after costs: 25 to 40%
- Beginning to evaluate second truck based on utilization data

The moving business rewards operators who treat both the operational side and the marketing side as professional disciplines. The ones who do both well scale to multiple trucks and six-figure annual income within 2 to 3 years.

Ready to get your first moves booked before you even launch? Book a free strategy call and let's talk about what your market looks like.